

K. Chandrasekhara Rao Back in the RECKONING

He is best known for his acerbic tongue, but Kalvakuntala Chandrasekhara Rao, 56, scored his biggest victory by remaining silent: fast unto death for the cause he was committed to—separate statehood for Telangana. Just a few months ago, his political future looked bleak after his party, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) was trounced, both in the Lok Sabha and Assembly polls. As his fast entered its 11th day, his health deteriorated rapidly and large parts of Andhra Pradesh threatened to erupt, statehood for Telangana was announced following a midnight meeting in Delhi between Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi and other senior members of the Cabinet. Rao came from the dead, politically and literally. For nine years since he founded the TRS, Rao ran a low intensity campaign on the streets banking on unorthodox political tactics. He relied on persuasive lobbying in which he impressed Sonia but not the Andhra strongman and late chief minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy (YSR). Then, in 2009 polls, he joined hands with the TDP and the communists, only to come a cropper. With YSR, the staunch opponent of statehood for Telangana dying in a chopper crash in September, Rao turned to the Gandhian strategy to demand a separate state. It worked. **by Amarnath K. Menon**



RAO TO SAMATHI/ANAND/Agastya



REUTERS

Sachin Tendulkar

As Always, MR INDIA

In which year did Sachin Tendulkar actually not make news? Could there be an uneventful time for the batsman who has scored more than 30,000 runs and 88 centuries, wearing hundreds of India shirts during at least 1,000 days of his life and ours? To Tendulkar, or rather around him, 2009 brought both a remembering and a recounting. He just went about being the methodical professional who lives inside the acclaimed, sparkling genius of his trade. Early on in 2009, he turned up in New Zealand where he'd first toured in 1990 merely considered one of a talented young Indian batsmen. Tendulkar returned there with the minimalist descriptions re-written and the fires of his talent strong. The fireworks weren't bad either. What set India alight this year wasn't the fact that Tendulkar became only the second cricketer in history to spend two decades in the international game. Or that he was the first to score 12,000 Test runs and in 2009 (at the time of going to print) had clocked in 1,505 runs and five centuries for India. Those numbers or the tsunami of tributes in November also weren't the reasons he was at the heart of the headlines. *That* is less quantifiable: the world's oldest in the batting business can make all of India feel young again. Remember his 175 in Hyderabad? He can, 20 years on, still keep in thrall a demographic that movie stars and politicians would kill for: men, women, children, slick city-folk, hick-town strugglers, everyone in a village with a TV set, Indians in every corner of the globe. Every class our economists define, every caste that can be appealed to for votes. That is Tendulkar's total audience. The headlines remain tangential.

by Sharda Ugra

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